

Running riot: Karnataka's Smaran Ravichandran finished with 950 runs in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy. **Facing page:** Saransh Jain and Auqib Nabi were among the standout bowlers in last season's Duleep Trophy.

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"Back in 2011-12, making the India A team was the biggest motivation for a domestic cricketer. Tours to New Zealand or the West Indies taught you a lot. They prepared you for international cricket," Choudhary says.

"Now, the IPL has become the biggest focus. Even state associations seem to be following that mindset. Players with strong T20 records often get the first opportunity, but four-day cricket is a completely different format. You can't judge a player's red-ball ability on what he does in T20 cricket..."

Choudhary insists the distinction between formats should remain clear.

"Four-day cricket tests your patience, temperament and skill over long spells. It deserves to be viewed separately from T20 cricket. The two formats require different skill sets," he says, pointing to Nabi's journey as an example.

"It isn't easy to be as consistent as he has been over the last couple of seasons. He was always in the mix, but perhaps never the first choice. As a domestic player, that makes you wonder what more you need to do. The BCCI should reward sustained performances in red-ball cricket.

"There are so many fast bowlers in the domestic circuit consistently bowling at 140 kmph. The talent is there. Players need to know that if they perform in four-day cricket, those performances will be recognised."

That perception isn't confined to one dressing room.

Several former domestic cricketers believe the selection ecosystem has become far more layered than it was a decade ago, with Ranji Trophy and Duleep Trophy performances now competing for



attention alongside India A tours and the IPL.

Paras Dogra has seen that change from close quarters. After nearly two decades in domestic cricket, the Jammu and Kashmir captain believes the route has become far less straightforward.

The seasoned campaigner, who still missed out on a North Zone berth for the Duleep Trophy despite leading J&K to its maiden Ranji Trophy title, says, "There are only one or two players who get picked purely on the back of domestic cricket now. The IPL seems to get preference."

"Earlier, IPL squads were bigger and there were more opportunities, even for rookies. Now, only one or two new players make it into the playing XI because most franchises stick with their core. That has reduced opportunities for domestic players," Dogra says.

He also believes team performances increasingly shape individual opportunities.

"Look at Nabi. He took around 60 wickets, and Jammu & Kashmir also had an excellent Ranji Trophy season. It's a similar case with Saransh (Jain). He's getting opportunities because he has been consistently performing and, at the same time, his team (Madhya Pradesh) has been doing well. We have also seen players miss out on the Duleep Trophy or India A despite scoring heavily because the team they represented didn't have a successful season."

There is another side to it: money.

"The opportunities are becoming narrower with the IPL's growing dominance. Most domestic cricketers come from humble backgrounds, and this is their only pathway. Those who make it to the IPL earn financial security. Those who don't continue to struggle," Dogra adds.

Lad agrees with parts of that argument, but also sees encouraging signs.

While he lauds the selectors for picking a 33-year-old Jain, sending